

able to the click-happy user includes using timestamps, sounds played when users are kicked out of chat rooms, adding a colon after usernames, stripping colours from messages in log files, docking the position of the chat window, different icons for user actions, and...

Plugins for Miranda are usually in the ZIP format, and need to be unzipped in the Plugin folder inside Miranda. After the plugin has been installed, open Miranda's options and navigate to Plugins. If the newly-installed plugin is present in the list, everything is set. Some things to watch out for is to always use the latest version of the plugin, and not using a Unicode plugin with an ANSI Miranda build. Most plugins come with their own readme files, where a detailed description on how to install the software would be provided.

There is a large list of available plugins at <http://addons.miranda-im.org/>. They are divided into broad categories like protocols, history, security and privacy, database, messaging, interface, etc. There's IM-History Client Suite, which allows you to store your chat history online securely; RSS News, which lets you read RSS feeds in Miranda; Chess4Net, which lets you play chess—these are just three of the thousands of plugins available!

4.3 VoIP

We have featured two VoIP software here: the fairly well-known Skype, and the comparatively new Gizmo. These services use peer-to-peer networks to make calls to phones and computers.

4.3.1 Skype

Skype runs on a variety of platforms: Windows, Linux, Mac OS X, Windows Mobile, and also phones like the Nokia N800/N810. The software is free for download (www.skype.com/intl/en/).

Skype calls can also be made from special phones, so you are not tied to your computer for making cheap long distance calls. The latest versions of Skype are 3.6.0.244 for Windows, 2.6.0.184 for Mac OS X, 1.4.0.118 for Linux, and 2.2.0.36 for Windows Mobile.